

CALIMESA FIRE DEPARTMENT
POLICY MANUAL
VOLUME 6
Policy: 600.13 Vehicle Accidents

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This guideline provides procedure for handling vehicle accidents.

ARRIVAL ON SCENE

1. The Driver Operator will position the apparatus in a way that will provide the best protection for the crew during rescue and operation activities.
2. The Officer will provide a scene size-up, assume command, determine type of incident, number of vehicles involved, extent of damage to vehicles involved, extent of injuries and if extrication is needed.
3. The Officer will request additional resources as needed (EMS, Med Flight).

SCENE SAFETY

1. Ensure that unauthorized/untrained personnel do not enter the hazardous area.
2. Traffic Hazards - Control

INCIDENT ACTIONS

Command will assign teams as needed for:

1. Fire and Hazard Control
2. Vehicle Stabilization
3. De-Energize Vehicle Electrical Systems
4. De-Activate Verify Vehicle Collision System (airbags)
5. Patient Care
6. Patient Extrication
7. Patient Care
8. Landing Zone

FREEWAY INCIDENTS:

Freeway incidents commonly involve multiple vehicles, multiple patients, and often vehicle fires. A major potential also exists for flammable liquid spills, fires or hazardous materials incidents.

This plan provides specific information and procedures to be used in handling incidents occurring on the freeway system. Unless specifically superseded by this plan, all other Calimesa Fire Department procedures shall be used in operations occurring on freeways.

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DISPATCH INFORMATION

When dispatching an incident on a freeway, Dispatch will provide the following information:

1. Type of Incident
2. Location
 - a. Freeway or access frontage
 - b. I-10
 - c. Cross street
3. Direction of Travel
 - a. If information indicates difficulty can be expected in reaching or locating the scene.
4. Traffic Conditions (if known)

RESPONSE

Dispatch may receive information on a freeway incident from Caltrans or a variety of other sources.

In most cases, the California Highway Patrol will report a freeway incident. Additionally, CHP may arrive first at an incident and may be able to provide updated information on traffic conditions and access. Any Information received from CHP must be relayed immediately to responding fire companies.

The Company Officer on a responding unit is responsible for redirecting other engines or having the Dispatch Center send additional engines if it becomes apparent that the first engine will be unable to reach the incident due to traffic congestion. If access problems are anticipated, or if the direction of travel is unknown, the Dispatch Center may send companies from opposite directions.

CANCELLED EN ROUTE

When responding to freeway emergencies and CHP is on-scene and has assumed command, it will be the responsibility of the CHP.

If fire units are canceled en route, they should not proceed into the scene unless re-dispatched. This creates unnecessary congestion and other traffic problems at the scene.

APPROACH AND STAGING

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Units responding to calls on the Freeway will respond Code 3 while on the Freeway mainline. However, alternating headlights and rear flashers may be used. Units should attempt to reach the scene in the direction of the reported incident unless otherwise instructed by CHP

In some cases, CHP may advise the best access is via the access frontage or by traveling against the normal traffic flow. Units should proceed in the opposite direction of normal flow only at the specific request of CHP when it is assured that all traffic has been stopped. Fire units should confirm traffic is stopped before entering the freeway against traffic.

On multiple unit responses, the first unit approaching or entering the freeway within a mile of the incident will report its identity, location and direction. Other units approaching will then stage preferably near an on-ramp to avoid premature commitment to the mainline or access frontage. Where appropriate to do so, these companies may block the access road to prevent additional traffic from entering the freeway.

It is the responsibility of the first unit to direct other units via alternate access if unable to reach the scene. Specific directions should be given regarding approach and direction for other companies when problems are encountered.

COMMAND

The first unit arriving on the scene of a multiple unit incident will determine if the CHP has established a Command Post. If Incident Command is in place, the first arriving fire department unit shall meet with the CHP Incident Commander for a briefing. The following should be covered:

1. Traffic Conditions
 - a. Stopped
 - b. One lane open
 - c. All lanes open
2. Fire/No Fire (smoke showing, working fire, fully involved) A follow-up report should indicate:
 - a. Number of patients/extent of injuries
 - b. Extrication Needed
 - c. Evacuation
 - d. Hazardous Materials Spill
 - e. What's Burning, including any hazardous product
3. Call for Necessary Help
 - a. Stage additional assistance as needed

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COMMAND POST LOCATION

The Command Post location should be carefully chosen for major incidents to provide access and a good view of the scene. The access frontage or an overpass provides a view of the scene for incidents on depressed roadway sections.

UNIFIED COMMAND

It's important to establish a single "Unified Command" Post as soon as possible. Key agencies at this Command Post will be the fire department, the California Highway Patrol, the California Department of Transportation (Caltrans) and if freeway traffic is being diverted to city streets, the appropriate city police will need to be party to the Command Post operation.

It's important to physically assemble all representatives at a single location as soon as possible. This may require the initial fire department commander to search out the CHP and Caltrans representatives. Once a physical location for the Command Post is determined, all agencies should advise their dispatchers of that location.

Dispatch centers must be advised of any changes in the Command Post.

When the fire department is first to arrive the Incident Commander must announce the command vehicles identity (i.e. Engine 21) and the vehicle's location (i.e. 50 feet east of the accident). Dispatch will relay the location to CHP. Dispatch must be advised of any change of Command Post locations.

LIAISON WITH CHP

In some occasions, particularly early in the incident, it may be more appropriate for a fire department representative to serve as a liaison officer to the CHP Incident Commander. This liaison should be a temporary function and should end when all agency representatives assemble Command Staff at a unified Command Post.

When the need to shut down freeway traffic is indicated Command must make a joint assessment of conditions with the CHP and police department. The logistical and traffic congestion problems created by a complete shutdown of freeway traffic may last for hours and affect a large area of the city. A decision to close the freeway must recognize these factors in relation to the safety of the incident.

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SPECIAL CONSIDERATIONS

Each company officer is responsible to research or know the location of hydrants and access to the freeway. Water supplies and other factors must be pre-planned by the first due officers. Some typical factors which must be considered:

EXAMPLES:

1. Early call for additional companies to handle lines that may have to be extended long distances over obstacles.
2. Relay pumping probabilities.
3. Special equipment is needed (tenders, foam, sand, diking materials, wreckers, etc.).
4. Early call for traffic control.
5. Sewers, drains, and pump stations (when dealing with spilled products).
6. Peak traffic hours create congestion and delays.
7. Access to the freeway (ladders, on/off ramps, etc.).
8. Hazardous Materials Team.

APPARATUS PLACEMENT

Whenever possible, place apparatus between oncoming traffic and operating personnel in order to protect the scene from approaching vehicles. Warning lights must be visible to oncoming traffic. Avoiding unnecessary blocking of traffic lanes will permit CHP to move traffic and relieve congestion.

Employ rear lights, flares, reflectors, or cones as required or as directed by the CHP Traffic control. Warning devices should be left to the CHP whenever possible. Communicate with the CHP whenever flammable liquid leaks, spills, etc., are present regarding using flares.

Leave one crewmember to watch the traffic and set up warning devices until the CHP arrives. Parking brakes are to be set, and the apparatus set with the wheels at an angle to the side.

1. Consider parking above or below (on access frontage) if the traffic conditions are such that entry is impossible or difficult.
2. A booster line or other hose line may be employed as a rope to ascend or descend to the freeway proper.
3. Where the freeway is elevated, a ladder is an effective means to gain access and to effect evacuation from above

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4. Only the apparatus that is necessary shall be taken onto the freeway, under the direction of Command. The first due unit will proceed into the scene. All other units will stage off the freeway, if possible, to await an assignment.
5. Position apparatus in a safe manner to protect the scene from traffic. Keep CHP aware that you are blocking a lane of traffic.
6. Do your job as rapidly as possible and then clear the traffic lanes.
7. In sections of depressed roadway, it is faster to have a company above "drop" a line than one advanced up the slope.
8. Several sections of the freeway have no access frontages and will require laying hose for long distances from on-ramps if a supply line is needed. Relay pumping and tenders should be considered in these cases.

Term	Definition	Other Names
"Access Road"	Road parallel to freeway	"Frontage Road"
"Against the Wall"	Area around the median barrier wall	"Inside Shoulder" "Median Wall"
"Distress Lane"	Usually refers to the area between the median barrier wall and the number one traffic lane; may also refer to the emergency lane	"Emergency Lane"
"Gore Point"	Area around freeway entrance and exit	"Gore"
"H.O.V. Lane"	High Occupancy Vehicle lane	"Car Pool Lane", "Bus Lane", or "Diamond Lane"
"Main lane"	Controlled access freeway	
"Shoulder"	Usually refers to the area off the roadway to the right of the emergency lane; may also refer to the median area near the left side of the roadway	

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"Unified Command" Command post consisting of more than
one agency

Lane numbering sequence: No. 1 is the traffic lane nearest the median or center, excluding the
H.O.V. lane.